

Narrative Viewpoint & Reliability — Part 1

Name: _____

Date: _____

Time: **60 min**

1 · COPY THIS DOWN — NOTES, STRUCTURES & TECHNIQUE

DEFINITIONS — COPY THE TABLE

TYPE	SIGNAL
First person	"I/we" — narrator is a character in the story
Third person limited	"he/she," but only one character's thoughts are shown
Third person omniscient	"he/she," and the narrator knows every character's thoughts

RELIABLE VS. UNRELIABLE NARRATOR

A narrator is **unreliable** when there is a gap between what they claim and what the evidence in the text actually shows — e.g. they insist they're calm while the description shows shaking hands. Always trust the evidence, not the narrator's own claims about themselves.

TECHNIQUE — 3 STEPS

1. Identify the viewpoint (1st person / 3rd limited / 3rd omniscient)
2. Check: does the narrator ever contradict themselves, or does other evidence contradict their claims?
3. If yes, explain the gap and what it suggests is really true

2 · PRACTICE — 4 PASSAGES, 20 QUESTIONS

EXTRACT A

I wasn't nervous at all, not really. I straightened my tie for the fourth time and checked my phone, though there were no new messages, and reminded myself that arriving early was simply sensible, not a sign of anything.

1. What narrative viewpoint is used here?

2. Find one piece of evidence that contradicts the narrator's claim of not being nervous.

3. Is this narrator reliable or unreliable? Explain using evidence.

4. What effect does this gap between claim and evidence have on the reader?

5. Rewrite the opening sentence as an honest, reliable version.

EXTRACT B

Mrs. Aldridge believed, with total confidence, that nobody in the office had noticed her leaving early on Fridays. Two desks away, Sam had noticed for six months and simply didn't care.

6. What narrative viewpoint is used here: 3rd limited or 3rd omniscient? How do you know?

7. What does the narrator reveal that Mrs. Aldridge herself doesn't know?

8. Is Mrs. Aldridge's own belief reliable?

9. What effect does knowing Sam's thoughts too have on the reader's understanding?

10. Could this extract work in 1st person from Mrs. Aldridge's viewpoint? Why/why not?

EXTRACT C

He walked into the kitchen, and immediately Dara knew something was wrong, though she couldn't yet have said what.

11. What narrative viewpoint is this?

12. Whose thoughts do we have access to?

13. Do we know what "he" is thinking? How do you know?

14. What effect does limiting us to only Dara's perspective create — suspense, distance, or comedy?

15. How would this extract change if written in 1st person as "he"?

EXTRACT D

I only took one biscuit, I swear, though the empty packet on the counter might suggest otherwise to anyone who wasn't there.

16. What viewpoint is this?

17. Identify the contradiction between the narrator's claim and the evidence given.

18. Is this narrator reliable or unreliable?

19. What tone does this contradiction create: comic or tragic?

20. Explain what the phrase "to anyone who wasn't there" reveals about the narrator's awareness of their own unreliability.

Apply this every time: Whenever a narrator insists something about themselves, check it against the actual described evidence in the same passage — the gap between claim and evidence is usually the real answer the question wants.

MARKING NOTES (FOR THE TUTOR)

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| 1. 1st person | 4. Creates humour/insight the narrator lacks |
| 2. straightened tie 4 times / checked phone repeatedly | 5. Model rewrite |
| 3. Unreliable — actions contradict the claim | 6. 3rd omniscient — reveals Sam's private thoughts too |

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|---|--|
| 7. That Sam already knows and doesn't mind | 14. Suspense |
| 8. No — she is mistaken | 15. Would need another method (dialogue etc.) to convey his feelings |
| 9. Adds dramatic irony | 16. 1st person |
| 10. No — she couldn't know Sam's thoughts in 1st person | 17. claims one biscuit vs empty packet |
| 11. 3rd limited | 18. Unreliable |
| 12. Dara's | 19. Comic |
| 13. No — narrator stays in Dara's head only | 20. Suggests the narrator knows they're not being fully honest |